



— TRAINING FREQUENCY

FULL BODY, BRO-SPLIT OR PUSH-PULL-LEGS?

How often should a muscle be trained per week? An overview of the key positions from training science – and what they mean for you.

BEGINNER TO INTERMEDIATE

NATURAL BODYBUILDING

15 POSITIONS

— INTRODUCTION

THE QUESTION EVERYONE ASKS SOONER OR LATER

The answers online contradict each other — some swear by full-body training, others by classic splits, others still by “one muscle, one day per week.” The truth: it depends on where you currently stand. This guide sums up the key positions from training science and practice — framed by the Kraftkompass method.

SECTIONS 01-07

FUNDAMENTALS

For all experience levels

SECTIONS 10-15

ADVANCED

For advanced lifters

— FUNDAMENTALS

01 FULL-BODY TRAINING FOR BEGINNERS

For true beginners the recommendation is clear: full-body training, three times per week. The load moved is still low early on, and the threshold for progress is low too. Repeating the same basic movements three times a week accelerates one thing above all: learning movement coordination.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This lines up directly with a principle from our beginner guide — early on, consistency with simple basic exercises counts more than complex programming. No reason to specialize early.

02 WHY ADVANCED LIFTERS HAVE TO SWITCH

Once an athlete leaves the beginner phase behind and has built notable strength, heavy full-body training three times a week stops working for two reasons: First, heavy training needs far more warm-up sets — a workout that used to take an hour suddenly stretches to **90 to 120 min**. Second, the **systemic fatigue** (load on the nervous system and hormones, not just the muscles) is no longer recoverable at that frequency over time.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This isn't a step back, it's a necessary adjustment. As you get stronger, you have to lower the frequency, not raise it further — more load automatically means more recovery needed.

03 THE SWEET SPOT: EVERY 3 TO 5 DAYS

For most advanced beginners and intermediates: hit each muscle group directly every **3 to 5 days** — so roughly two to three times per week. Two proven structures:

UPPER / LOWER

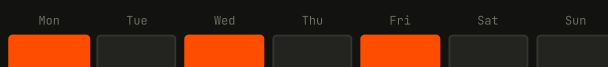
4 Days / Week



Each muscle gets a growth stimulus every 3–4 days.

ALTERNATING SPLIT

3 Days / Week



Each muscle every 5 days — good for older lifters, easier on the joints.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

For most of our clients the most practical range — enough frequency for progress, enough recovery to train clean instead of running yourself into the ground.

04 WHY CLASSIC BRO-SPLITS ARE USUALLY SUBOPTIMAL

Plans where each muscle group is trained directly only once per week ("Monday is chest day") are considered suboptimal for most natural lifters. The reason: muscle protein synthesis (the biological process of muscle building after a workout) stays elevated for only about **48 hours** — after that it drops back to baseline. A muscle stimulated only once a week misses several windows for additional growth.

EXCEPTION

Extremely strong, advanced athletes (e.g. well over **150 kg** bench press) sometimes deliberately use lower frequencies (every 4–10 days) to protect joints and tendons from the enormous absolute load. An exception for very advanced lifters, not a recommendation for beginners.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

A bro-split can work if you're psychologically attached to it and train with high intensity — consistency and effort ultimately weigh more than the mathematically perfect split. But as the default for most: higher frequency beats the bro-split.

05 THE REAL LIMIT: NOT THE MUSCLES, BUT THE JOINTS

An often-overlooked point: muscles recover surprisingly fast. The true limiting factor at high training frequency is joints and tendons — they take considerably longer. A proven system against this: **Heavy-Light-Medium (HLM)** — on lighter training days you use different exercises and higher rep ranges to deliberately unload the joints while still training the muscle.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This is ECM thinking in its purest form — force and stimulus belong in the muscle, not the joint. A high frequency that ruins your joints is no success, no matter how much muscle it builds.

06 SET QUALITY OVER PURE FREQUENCY MATH

An important, often underrated point: at exactly the same weekly volume, current research shows frequency makes little difference for pure muscle growth. The real advantage of higher frequency lies elsewhere — it lets you spread the same volume across several fresh sessions instead of grinding it out in one increasingly exhausted session.

Spread **15 sets** across three sessions instead of one, and you train every set with full force and focus — without later sets losing quality to fatigue (“**junk volume**” — sets that, due to exhaustion, barely deliver any real training stimulus).

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

Frequency is a tool, not an end in itself. It's not about training as often as possible, but about distributing your weekly volume so that every single set counts.

07 SPECIALIZATION FOR ADVANCED LIFTERS

If you've been training for a long time, you can no longer grow every muscle at maximum volume at once — the energy required exceeds your total recovery capacity. The solution: **specialization cycles** — for 6 to 8 weeks you deliberately prioritize two muscle groups with high volume, while the rest of the body is dialed down to pure maintenance volume (about 2–3 sets per muscle group).

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This ties directly into our principle on maintaining gains (see the guide "Compounds vs. Isolation by Experience Level") — maintenance needs far less stimulus than building. It's exactly this difference that makes specialization possible in the first place.

08 THE HYBRID SPLIT: BASEMENT BODYBUILDING

Basement Bodybuilding (Landon) approaches the frequency question less through lab values and more through real joint stress at high strength levels. His experience: once you get genuinely strong, a frequency of **3×/week** for the same heavy compound (e.g. the squat) often becomes unbearable for the joints — for him personally, too high a squat frequency led to chronic problems in the sacroiliac joint (the joint between the sacrum and the pelvis) and the calf muscles.

His solution for advanced intermediates: a hybrid system combining an Upper/Lower and a Push-Pull-Legs split. It keeps the weekly volume but lowers the frequency for the heaviest compounds and maximizes recovery. One especially clever detail — his **“arm trick”**: biceps is trained on the push day, triceps on the pull day, the exact reverse of the intuitive pairing.

ARMS

4×/week



2× direct + 2× indirect (biceps on push, triceps on pull day)

LARGE MUSCLE GROUPS

2×/week



Stay in the optimal 2× frequency window.

The effect: since the arms are already loaded indirectly during heavy pressing (triceps assists) and pulling (biceps assists), this swapped pairing means the arms get stimulus **4×** per week — while the large muscle groups stay in their optimal **2×** frequency window. No separate, time-consuming arm day needed.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This confirms section 05 from real-world practice — it's the joints, not the muscles, that set the true limit at high frequency. The arm trick also shows how to cleverly raise frequency for smaller muscles without any extra training time.

🔗 TIM'S PERSPECTIVE

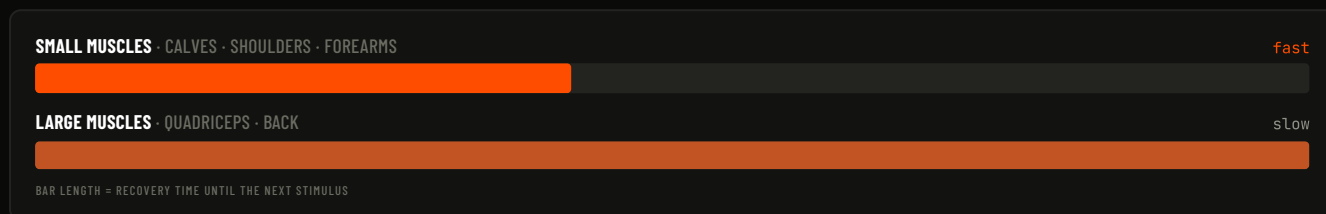
I've tried just about every split in my own career — 2-day split, Push-Pull-Legs, bro-split, sometimes blindly following pre-made programs (Athlean-X's "Perfect Workout" series was with me for a long time) — until at some point I started building my own, somewhat unusual but tailored-to-me plans. I made clear progress with practically every approach.

What works best for me personally, even if I can't prove it scientifically, is a Push-Pull-Legs system with two slightly different versions of each day — every muscle is trained twice a week, but the focus shifts slightly: Push day 1 more chest, Push day 2 starts with the overhead press because it's my personal favorite lift. Pull day 1 more lats, Pull day 2 more upper back. That keeps everything balanced for me, and I can give it everything on any given day without a guilty conscience, without neglecting a muscle group. The side effect: I can deliberately swap a very demanding exercise for a lighter machine variation at the next session for the same muscle group to spare my nervous system — and I can regularly add isolation work for often-neglected smaller muscles without having to grind through 20 exercises in a single day.

That's exactly the point I want to give my clients: there is no single truth. Every expert cited here achieved massive success with a different approach — because each of them listened to their own body. I'm showing you one approach as a starting point, but I don't expect it to stay the best one for you 1:1. Try out what works for you.

09 NOT EVERY MUSCLE RECOVERS AT THE SAME SPEED

All the numbers so far — 3 to 5 days, 48 to 72 hours — are averages, not fixed laws. One important factor often gets lost here: different muscle groups recover at different speeds. Smaller muscles (calves, forearms, side delts) tend to recover faster than large ones (quadriceps, back).



A concrete example from practice: if you push a leg session especially hard, close to true muscle failure, you sometimes notice on the next scheduled leg day that the quads still feel noticeably weak and wobbly — even though the “prescribed” frequency gap was met long ago.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

*The numbers in this guide are a good starting point, but no substitute for listening to your own body. Training frequency should follow your actual readiness and recovery on that specific day — the core of **autoregulation** (making decisions based on how you genuinely feel that day instead of rigidly by the calendar). A dedicated, deeper guide on this is coming — rigid numbers are always only the starting point, never the last word.*

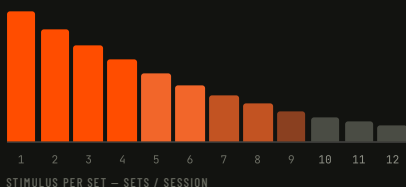
GOING DEEPER FOR **ADVANCED LIFTERS**

The following concepts go beyond the fundamentals — relevant once you already have a solid training rhythm and want to get into the details. If you only want the basics, you can stop after section 07 — the fundamentals stand on their own.

— **ADVANCED**

10 THE 48-72-HOUR RULE OF THUMB

A simple, robust approach from **Steve Hall** and **Pascal Flor** (Revive Stronger): **1 to 3 high-quality sets per muscle group every 48 to 72 hours**. Which split delivers it is secondary — holding to this biological frequency window is the real lever.



DIMINISHING RETURNS

Beyond **10-12** hard sets for a muscle in a single session, the extra growth stimulus flattens out sharply (Jake Remmit, via Steve Hall). From here, an additional session per week does more than cramming even more sets into one session.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

The same idea as set quality from section 06 — just with a concrete number. When a session gets too full, that's your signal to raise the frequency instead of piling on more volume.

11 ADJUSTING FREQUENCY IN A CUT VS. A BULK

In a bulk recovery capacity is highest — large muscle groups can be trained up to 3×/week, smaller ones like calves or shoulders even 4–5×/week. In a deep caloric deficit recovery drops noticeably: cutting from 3× to 2×/week for large muscle groups (e.g. switching from Upper/Lower to Push-Pull-Legs) creates larger recovery windows and protects set quality.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

Your training plan should change along with your nutrition phase — what works in a bulk overloads you in a cut. Not a contradiction, but adapted management of the same principles.

12 THE PSYCHOLOGICAL FACTOR

A point that's often overlooked: very high frequency (e.g. the same heavy exercise every other day) is demanding not only physically but also mentally. After one or two training blocks, many athletes crave a lower frequency — regardless of whether the body could still handle it.

A practical solution from experienced coaches: deliberately group exercises that already tax each other — for example back and hamstrings on the same day, since heavy hip-hinge movements like RDLs already load the lower back heavily anyway.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

A plan that reads perfectly on paper but that you can't sustain mentally is worth nothing. Psychological sustainability is part of the programming, not a nice-to-have.

— ADVANCED

13 THE CALENDAR ISN'T SACRED

A common mistake: forcing training into a rigid 7-day week. Advanced lifters often use **asynchronous cycles** — a rotating system like Push/Pull/Legs/Upper/Lower/Rest can take, say, **9 to 10 days** to repeat. This takes the pressure off fixed weekdays and ensures that heavy compounds like squats and deadlifts sit much further apart — sparing the joints and allowing higher strength output per session.



— ADVANCED

14 “FIRST TOUCHES”: THE FIRST SET COUNTS MOST

An explanation for why frequency works at all: the very first set for a muscle in a session triggers by far the largest part of the growth signal. Every following set in the same session has noticeably diminishing returns.

Do **12 sets** of chest in a single weekly session and you generate a lot of fatigue for comparatively little extra stimulus. The same 12 sets spread across **3 sessions** produce 3 strong “first-contact” stimuli at a fraction of the fatigue.

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

This is the scientific basis for section 06 — distributed volume is more efficient than concentrated volume. Now you know why.

15 A SPLIT TRAP YOU SHOULD AVOID

A frequently underrated problem: the “**torso-limb split**” (e.g. chest/back on one day, arms/shoulders the next). Because arms and shoulders are heavily taxed as **synergists** (supporting muscles that assist in the main lift) in every heavy chest and back session, the elbow and shoulder joints are under load on almost every training day of the week — a direct route to chronic tendon irritation (tendonitis).

KRAFTKOMPASS-FIX

Don't plan by muscle groups alone, but by which joints actually get a rest on which day. An Upper/Lower split avoids this trap by design.

SUMMED UP

BEGINNER

Full body, 3×/week — focus on technique and coordination.

ADVANCED

2–3×/week per muscle group, Upper/Lower or hybrid split — the most practical range for most. Rule of thumb: 1–3 good sets per muscle every 48–72 h.

VERY ADVANCED / STRONG

Lower frequency for heavy compounds possible to protect the joints — plus targeted specialization cycles for weak points. Asynchronous cycles instead of a rigid 7-day week as an option.

ALWAYS

Set quality over frequency math. Upper/Lower instead of torso-limb to spare the joints. Not every muscle recovers at the same speed — smaller ones usually faster than large. And: consistency — sustainable psychologically too — beats the perfect split on paper.

MOST IMPORTANT

There is no single right frequency. The numbers here are starting points — listen to your actual recovery, not just the calendar.

